

WEEK ONE

LN905 Academic Writing & Assignment Task Booklet



Assignment Task: Choosing an Essay Question

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Week One –

Week 1: Lesson 1

Week 1: Lesson 1

Assignment: Essay & Key Deadlines

Your assignment is to write a 2,000-word essay on a topic relevant to your chosen academic field.

Final Deadline:

Wednesday Week 5

Further deadlines:

1. **Choice of essay question & brief explanation of choice of question** Sunday Week 1
2. **Annotated bibliography:** Sunday Week 2
3. **Detailed essay plan:** Sunday Week 3
4. **First draft:** Sunday Week 4

Your essay should contain the following:

- A minimum of 6 academic references
- An introduction containing a clear thesis statement
- Clearly structured paragraphs
- A conclusion
- A separate page for the list of references/bibliography



Please ensure that your work is correctly formatted:

- Use Times New Roman (or other similarly clear typeface), font size 11 or 12
- Use line spacing 1.5 or double
- Leave a space/line between paragraphs
- Justify your text
- Add page numbers

Provide a cover sheet including:

- Essay Title
- Your name
- Tutor's name
- Date
- Word count



Compare and contrast the roles and modes of operation of the Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development (OECD) and the International Monetary Fund (IMF).

Student: Joseph Taylor

Tutor: Simon Roberts

Date: 27th August 2025

Word count: 1,995 words

Academic Writing at LSE

While you are studying at LSE, you will do a lot of writing! This is likely to include: formative assessments, summative assessments, exams and dissertations.

A: Read the programme structure for your degree and complete the table below

What is the name of your degree programme?	MS of Data Science
Will you have to do any compulsory modules? If so, what are the course codes for those modules?	<u>ST445</u> <i><u>Managing and Visualising Data</u></i> <u>ST447</u> <i><u>Data Analysis and Statistical Methods</u></i> <u>ST443</u> <i><u>Machine Learning and Data Mining</u></i> <u>ST498</u> <i><u>Capstone Project</u></i>
Will you be able to choose any modules? If so, which modules are you likely to choose (list the course codes)?	<u>MA407</u> Algorithms and Computation (0.5) <u>#</u> <u>MY459</u> Computational Text Analysis and Large Language Models (0.5) <u>#</u> <u>MY461</u> Social Network Analysis (0.5) <u>MY470</u> Computer Programming (0.5) <u>ST405</u> Unsupervised Machine Learning and Multivariate Data Analysis (0.5) <u>ST411</u> Generalised Linear Modelling and Survival Analysis (0.5) <u>#</u> <u>ST418</u> Advanced Time Series Analysis (0.5) <u>#</u> <u>ST429</u> Statistical Methods for Risk Management (0.5) <u>#</u> <u>ST436</u> Financial Statistics (0.5) <u>#</u> <u>ST444</u> Computational Data Science (0.5) <u>#</u> (suspended 2025/26)

	ST446 Distributed Computing for Big Data (0.5) # ST449 Artificial Intelligence (0.5) # ST451 Bayesian Machine Learning (0.5) # ST454 Bayesian Data Analysis (0.5) # (suspended 2025/26) ST455 Reinforcement Learning (0.5) # ST456 Deep Learning (0.5) # ST457 Graph Data Analytics and Representation Learning (0.5) # ST458 Financial Statistics II (0.5) ST459 Quantum Computation and Information (0.5) #
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B: Now use the course guides to explore the types of writing you will have to do

Course?	Formative Assessment?	Summative Assessment?	Exam?
eg DV423	One 2,000-word essay	None	Take-home assessment
ST445	2 problem sets	2 assessed problem sets (30%)	Take-home data-management and visualisation project (70%)
ST447	5 exercises using statistical methods and R	Data-analysis project (15%)	2-hour January exam (85%)
ST443	5 problem sets: theory and computer-based data problems	Machine-learning/data-mining project (30%)	2-hour Spring exam (70%)
ST498	Draft and partial reports; supervisor feedback	Group report (max. 50 pages) and individual report; project 100%	None



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C: Compare your findings with other students. How similar/different are your courses?



What is an Academic Essay?

You've probably had experience of writing essays for IELTS but the requirements to do well in an IELTS essay are not the same as the requirements to do well in an LSE essay.

Compare the essays below. Essay A is an IELTS-style essay while Essay B is an essay written by an LN905 student as a piece of Timed Writing. What are some of the differences? (Note: the 'LSE essay' is not perfect and should not be considered a model)

A: IELTS Essay

Should universities resist Artificial Intelligence?

Artificial Intelligence (AI) has permeated various sectors of society, and education is no exception. The question arises whether universities should resist this technological advancement or embrace it. This essay will explore both perspectives before reaching a conclusion.

AI has the potential to revolutionize the educational landscape. It can provide personalized learning experiences, identifying and addressing individual student's weaknesses. AI-powered systems can also automate administrative tasks, freeing up time for educators to focus on teaching. Furthermore, AI can facilitate research, sifting through vast amounts of data more efficiently than humans.

Despite these advantages, there are valid concerns about the integration of AI in universities. One is the fear of job displacement. There are also ethical concerns, such as data privacy and the risk of AI systems making decisions that could adversely affect students without clear accountability. Finally, there is the risk of universities becoming overly dependent on technology, which could be problematic in the event of technical issues or cyber-attacks.

In a nutshell, while AI offers many potential benefits for universities, it is not without its drawbacks. It is crucial for universities to approach AI with caution, implementing it in a way that enhances the educational experience.

B: LN905 Timed Writing Essay

Should universities resist Artificial Intelligence (AI)?

Although artificial intelligence (AI) has existed for around 60 years (Hardman, 2023a), its newest developments have raised questions about traditional pedagogic methods as well as the role of teachers and educational institutions (Hardman, 2023b). Chatbots such as ChatGPT, for example, have arisen questions about integrity, bias in academic contexts and the roles in knowledge acquisition (Sullivan et al., 2023). This essay will argue that the resistance to AI in universities might be counterproductive and that new approaches and considerations must be taken.

According to The Royal Society (2019), AI is the science of making machines intelligent and able to imitate the processes of human thinking. In the year 2023, we witnessed the release of unprecedentedly powerful AIs. Therefore, multiple ethical questions have emerged. In the case of universities, a concern about how to respond to the dangers and threats of AI to traditional educational models has come to light. In response, many universities have opted for banning its use, and have invested in software that helps teachers to identify AI usage in students' homework. However, this seems to be an ineffective approach as the detection software is fallible and the job market is currently demanding the integration of AI in the work environment (Hardman, 2023b).

The authors that embrace of AI in the classroom are multiple (Hardman, 2023; Herbold et al., 2023; Sullivan et al., 2023; Khan 2023). According to their view, embracing AI is a necessary movement in the academia, as to fight against it seems futile. If universities focus their efforts on the creative and critical usage of AI, the pedagogic process could be boosted for both teachers and students, as many processes could be simplified and the educational process personalized (Khan, 2023). Hardman (2023a) argues that AI has increased human's efficiency by 35%. In that regard, its usage seems to be beneficial. Nonetheless, is our duty to think how to integrate AI in academic contexts in a way in which we can reduce its potential damages and promote creativity and critical thinking.

Khan (2023) suggests that the usage of AI as a tutor could democratize and make better the students' learning processes. This is because it could be used to provide a personalized high-quality education, while promoting both creativity and critical thinking. However, the nature of the teacher-student relationship must be considered. If we think about teachers not only as people that transfer academic knowledge, but also as mentors, the AI approach acquires new perspectives. The richness of human dialogue cannot be replaced by a machine. Likewise, questions about the acquisition of soft skills arise. How can a student learn to argue if there is no true discussion? Or how can they learn the value of difference and tolerance when no true human interaction is in play?

Overall, it is important for universities not to resist the implementation of AI in their curriculums, but to remain critical as the gains of human interaction are difficult to replace.

When you finish, look at the table on the next page for some suggested answers.

If you have time, examine the coursework essay in Appendix A.

Week One Answer Key

Lesson One

IELTS essay	LSE essay
Lacks a thesis statement: <i>This essay will explore both perspectives before reaching a conclusion.</i>	Has a clear thesis statement: <i>This essay will argue that the resistance to AI in universities might be counterproductive and that new approaches and considerations must be taken.</i>
Has no references to the literature or other sources.	Has many references e.g. <i>Although artificial intelligence (AI) has existed for around 60 years (Hardman, 2023a)...</i> <i>According to The Royal Society (2019)...</i> <i>Khan (2023) suggests that</i>
Has a standard IELTS structure which is quite descriptive:	Has a more analytical/argumentative structure:

▪ Introduction ▪ Advantages ▪ Disadvantages ▪ Conclusion	▪ Introduction with thesis (i.e., universities should not resist AI) ▪ Counter argument & rebuttal ▪ Argument 1 ▪ Argument 2 ▪ Conclusion
Does not always support arguments with explanations or evidence and there is a preference for breadth over depth. For example, this paragraph raises four concerns about AI but does not discuss any of them in detail. <i>Despite these advantages, there are valid concerns about the integration of AI in universities. One is the fear of job displacement. There are also ethical concerns, such as data privacy and the risk of AI systems making decisions that could adversely affect students without</i>	Supports arguments with explanations and evidence e.g. <i>However, this seems to be an ineffective approach (ARGUMENT) as the detection software is fallible and the job market is currently demanding the integration of AI in the work environment (EXPLANATION) (Hardman, 2023b) (EVIDENCE).</i>

clear accountability. Finally, there is the risk of universities becoming overly dependent on technology, which could be problematic in the event of technical issues or cyber-attacks.



Week 1: Lesson 2

Introductions

Task 1

Read the following introduction and discuss how it could be improved. Consider the style of the writing and how the introduction is structured. Is there anything else that is missing or that should be cut?

Introduction

So basically I'm going to be writing about social media and how it messes with people's heads. Everyone uses Instagram and TikTok these days, right? Like literally everyone is on their phone 24/7 and it's kind of obvious that this probably isn't great for mental health or whatever. I personally spend way too much time scrolling and it makes me feel bad about myself sometimes, so I think this is a really interesting topic that a lot of people can relate to.

In this essay I will be talking about lots of different things related to this subject. There's loads of research out there that basically proves social media is bad. This is a huge problem in today's society and something really needs to be done about it. I hope you enjoy reading my essay!!



Improved version

The proliferation of social media platforms has fundamentally reshaped patterns of human communication and self-presentation, raising significant questions about the psychological consequences of sustained digital engagement. Scholars have increasingly turned their attention to this relationship; Twenge et al. (2018) demonstrated a statistically significant correlation between heavy social media use and elevated rates of depression and loneliness among adolescents, while Vogel et al. (2014) identified social comparison as a key mechanism through which platforms such as Instagram negatively affect users' self-evaluations. Despite this growing body of evidence, the precise conditions under which social media use becomes psychologically harmful remain insufficiently theorised. This essay argues that the mental health impact of social media is not uniform, but is instead mediated by individual usage patterns and platform design features. To develop this argument, the essay first examines the existing empirical literature, before critically analysing the role of algorithmic content curation in shaping user experience.

How would you describe the three different sections outlined in different colours above?

Blue -

Green -

Red -

Conclusions

Read the following conclusion and identify the main functions indicated by the different coloured sections.

This essay has examined the relationship between social media use and mental health outcomes, arguing that the psychological impact of these platforms is not uniform but is instead shaped by individual usage patterns and the design features embedded within algorithmic content curation systems. Drawing on the empirical literature, it was shown that exposure to social comparison mechanisms and engagement-maximising algorithms significantly amplifies the risk of depression and diminished self-worth, particularly among adolescent users. These findings suggest that future research should move beyond broad correlational studies to investigate the specific platform-level variables — such as feed ranking logic and notification design — that mediate psychological harm. At the policy level, this analysis points to the need for regulatory frameworks that hold platform developers accountable for the measurable mental health consequences of their design choices, rather than treating such outcomes as incidental. Understanding social media's psychological effects as a structural rather than purely individual phenomenon remains an urgent priority for both scholars and policymakers alike.

Blue –

Red –

Green –

Purple –

Week 1: Lesson 3

Analysing Essay Questions

These are questions from LSE examination papers. Highlight the question words.

1. 'Most successful nationalisms in the 20th century are beneficiaries of imperial collapse'. Discuss with reference to EITHER Europe after 1918 OR European decolonisation after 1945 OR the breakup of the Soviet Union after 1989. (GV479 Nationalism)
2. 'The response of the United Nations to international terrorism has put one of its foundational principles – the protection of human rights – at risk' Discuss. (LL475 Terrorism and the Rule of Law)
3. Compare and contrast the roles and modes of operation of the Organisation for Economic Cooperation and Development (OECD) and the International Monetary Fund (IMF). (IR429 Economic Diplomacy)
4. Discuss critically the strengths and weaknesses of 'Anti-Globalisation' arguments in respect of:
 - a. International capital flows, and
 - b. Personal income inequality. (MG412 Globalisation and Strategy)
5. In what circumstances does a free press undermine processes of democratisation? (MC417 Democracy and the Media)
6. Is citizen participation democratising? If so, why? If not, why not? (SO407 Politics and Society)
7. IT does not matter: It is a commodity, infrastructure, like electricity or the telephone.' Assess the validity of this statement and suggest the different ways in which IT might well matter to a business. Use strategic alignment frameworks and case examples to illustrate your points. (IS472 Global Strategy, Management and Information Systems)

Look at one or two questions in more detail and think about the following:

1. What do you have to do?
 - a) Take a position in an academic debate?
 - b) Suggest solutions to a problem?
 - c) Evaluate the effectiveness/validity of a policy, model, theory...?
 - d) Identify the causes of a situation?
 - e) Other? If so what?
2. How many parts are there to the question? Are these of equal importance?
3. Are there any restrictions on the topic? (i.e. time / place)
4. What terms need defining?
5. Is there any problematic vocabulary?
6. Do you have a view with regard to the question?
7. How might you structure a response?



Choosing an Essay Question

For your assignment, you have to choose your own essay question. To make this assignment as beneficial as possible, you should choose an essay question which will prepare you for your degree. Here are some suggestions:

A: Look at the LSE Moodle sites of courses you will study during your degree.

Some Moodle sites require an enrolment key but hopefully you will be able to access some of the courses which are relevant to you. The content of Moodle sites varies. Usually, you will be able to see what topics are covered each week and you may find seminar questions or questions for formative/summative coursework essays. You could use these directly or adapt them.

B: Look at past exam papers

You can find these by:

- Going to the [Library homepage](#)
- Clicking on '[Search our catalogues](#)'
- Scrolling down to '[Exam papers](#)'

C: Look carefully at the course descriptions for your degree programme

What topics will you cover? What are the main issues / questions / debates? Can you create an essay question based on something that you will be studying.



On Moodle you need to submit:

- a) Your essay question
- b) Why you have chosen that question (i.e. how it will prepare you for your degree)

Task

The best way to get ideas for a potential assignment question is to look at past paper exam questions. These can be found on the following page:

<https://www.lse.ac.uk/library/using-the-library/catalogues>

- Search some of the course that you are going to take on your degree programme. Try to find some possible questions that you might use for your assignment. If necessary you can adapt the question so that it is more feasible.
- If you have time, write a draft version of your assignment question and show it to your teacher.

Appendix A

Example of a coursework essay

1. Look at the essay question (below) and discuss:
 - a) What are the question words?
 - b) Are there any terms which require definition?
 - c) What are (some of) the possible answers to the essay question?

Essay Question:

Is it really the case that institutions matter most in explaining patterns of differential development?

2. Read the introduction:
 - a) How is the introduction structured?
 - b) Do you think the introduction is effective (Why/Why not)?
 - c) Does the introduction contain any useful language?
3. Read the conclusion:
 - a) How is the conclusion structured?
 - b) Do you think the conclusion is effective (Why/Why not)?
 - c) Does the conclusion contain any useful language?
4. Look at the main body of the essays:
 - a) How many paragraphs are there (excluding the introduction and conclusion)?
 - b) Broadly, how are the main bodies of the paper structured?
 - c) Can you identify the purpose of each paragraph?
 - d) In general, do you think the essays have a clear structure?
5. Highlight examples of linking/signposting language.
6. Is there sufficient argument? Give examples of 'argument language'.
7. Look at the references and reference list.
 - a) How many references are there?
 - b) How many group references are there? What is the difference between a group reference and an individual reference?
 - c) Are there any discrepancies between the references in the essay and those in the list?
 - d) What reporting expressions are used?

- e) What tense are the reporting verbs in & why?
- f) Where are the references placed: at the end of the sentence; after the author's name or elsewhere? Do they make the reference clear?

What are the main factors that determine differential development?

Student essay - used with permission

Over the past decade, there have been a number of attempts made by scholars of development economics to account for the disparity in the rate of economic growth and the ways in which growth has been experienced by developing countries around the globe. This essay will focus on two factors identified as determinant elements, namely, institutions and geography. It will then contend that, while the argument that institutions matter provides a more cogent explanation for growth than the idea that geography is the main determinant, one should be wary of a simplistic causal link between institutions and economic growth, as the nature of the institutions is conditioned by the context in which they exist.

The assertion that institutions are the key to economic growth has been put forward by Rodrik et al (2002) and Acemoglu et al (2002). Rodrik et al assess the individual effect that institutions, integration, and geography have on a country's GDP per capita using regression analysis and contend that "quality of institutions trumps everything else" (Rodrik et al 2002: 4). On a similar note, Acemoglu et al also emphasise the institutions' effect, that is, the existence of "institutions ensuring secure property rights for a broad cross section of society" (Acemoglu et al 2002: 1235) will result in a better economic performance. By contrast, Sachs evinces his scepticism towards such arguments. Rather, he attributes Africa's persistent poverty to geographical factors such as its tropical climate, distance to coastal areas, prevalence of infectious diseases and scarcity of natural resources, thus suggesting that more foreign aid should be directed towards overcoming these geographical disadvantages (Sachs 2003; Sachs et al 2001; Bloom and Sachs 1998).

While both perspectives provide insight into the issues faced by many developing countries, the view that institutions matter most is more convincing for the following two reasons. Firstly, it explains variations in growth over time. As an example, Acemoglu et al underscore the "reversal" trend in the income levels of former European colonies from 1500 to the present day, that is, some countries which were relatively wealthy back in 1500 have become relatively poor over time and vice versa. This indicates a correlation between the nature of institutions established by European colonizers and the subsequent economic growth experienced in post-colonial years (Acemoglu et al 2002). By contrast, the idea that "location is the ultimate fixed effect" (Collier in Bloom and Sachs 1998: 275) does not account for chronologically dynamic contexts. Secondly, the view that geography is the key determinant of economic success is over-simplistic. Consequently, Sachs is

criticized for seeing Africa as inherently disadvantaged due to its tropical climate (Collier and Gunning, 1999). This fails to account for cases such as Botswana, a landlocked country with low population density that has experienced rapid economic growth despite its unfavourable geographical features. Botswana is an example where policies rather than “destiny” have played a larger role in economic growth (Collier and Gunning 1999:17).

Furthermore, while Sachs asserts that more financial aid should be provided by wealthy countries to enable developing countries to mitigate specific geographical problems, the effect of aid depends heavily on the quality of institutions. Not only would the act of giving aid be futile if the money is misused or misallocated by certain interest groups, but it may even be detrimental to economic growth, leaving the recipients in the vicious circle of aid dependency. This is manifested in the fact that by 2004 Africa had already received the equivalent amount of six Marshall Plans but to little effect (Taylor 2005: 303). According to Taylor, the existence of a mechanism “aimed at encouraging local investment and discouraging capital flight” (ibid: 305) is vital in order for financial aid programmes to be effective.

For the reasons discussed above, it is more likely that institutions as opposed to geography, when taken individually, play a larger role in determining the patterns of economic growth, implying there is higher likelihood of achieving economic prosperity by having better quality institutions than by being endowed with favourable geographical features. This is endorsed by Rodrik et al, who provide powerful findings from their econometric analysis which reject the effect of geography once the institutions variables are controlled for (Rodrik et al 2002). However, there is a pitfall in focusing exclusively on the effect of institutions as a prerequisite for growth. Delineating the causal effect of institutions on economic growth can sometimes be problematic. While institutions may have an immense impact on economic performance, institutions themselves are contingent upon and controlled by myriad factors. Przeworski claims that this is due to the endogeneity of institutions, that is to say, “their form and their functioning depend on the conditions under which they emerge and endure”, institutions established in a certain context do not always function as expected when implemented elsewhere (Przeworski 2005: 527-528).

To illustrate the point, different patterns of demographic transition among developing countries may be taken as an example. According to Bloom and Williamson, a rapid decline in mortality and fertility rates contributed considerably to the economic boom of East Asia in the late twentieth century (Bloom and Williamson 1998). While such pattern of demographic transition is a relatively universal phenomenon, starting with a decline in mortality succeeded by a decline in fertility, the speed of the transition has been extremely slow in Africa, due to “a combination of low socio-economic development” in terms of education for example, and “socio-cultural practices” opting for a larger family (ibid: 243-7). East Asian countries in which rapid transition has taken place had “social, economic, and political institutions and policies that allowed them to realize the growth potential created by the transition” (ibid: 419) and thus

was able to take full advantage of it, whereas in Africa, the persistent high fertility rate has created the burden of youth dependency, an obstacle to growth (Bloom and Sachs 1998: 245). What this contrast implies is that although institutions may have been the key to success in East Asia, it was conditional upon the particular phase of the demographic transition they were undergoing. Moreover, in explaining Africa's stalled demographic transition, one must also be cognizant of the impact of social norms and cultural factors.

Another example of the ways in which institutions function are influenced by conditions is depicted in the account of the Rwandan genocide by Diamond. Counter to the common narrative of the genocide as a civil war resulting from ethnic hatred between the Hutu and Tutsi, Diamond chooses to adapt the Malthusian theory which regards shortage of land and food as ultimate restraint on explosive population (Diamond 2005). He places emphasis on the role of the population pressure causing scarcity of land and food, among other factors including the desire of the ruling elites to consolidate their power, which led to the conflict and atrocity (ibid.). These examples illustrate how exogenous factors such as demography and geography may operate to influence the ways in which institutions emerge and the form they take, in other words, whether they are made conducive or adverse to the promotion of economic growth.

In search of explanation for the discrepancies in the patterns of economic growth among developing countries, this essay has first discussed the extent to which institutions and geography arguments may be valid. When assessed individually, the institutions argument is deemed more persuasive owing to its advantage of allowing for the notion of time to be brought into analysis, and due to the exceedingly simple and deterministic view of the geography argument. Nevertheless, there is a risk in assessing the observed causality link between institutions and economic performance on its own, as the nature of the institutions is contingent upon the conditions in which they exist. One needs to be wary and look further into the social, cultural contexts as well as the exogenous and seemingly less relevant factors such as demography and geography.

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Appendix B:

Academic Language – key areas to consider:

A: Use of 'I' in essays

The use of the first person in academic writing depends on what academic field you are writing in.

- From your experience, is it widely used in your field, and would you feel comfortable using it?
- Are there any advantages to using 'I'?

If you feel uncomfortable using 'I' or it is not common in your field, there are alternatives.

- For example, instead of: *I will argue that...*
- You can write: *This paper will argue that...*

However, avoid ambiguous phrases, such as: '*It is argued that...*'. The reader needs to know who argues...

Also, avoid overly subjective use of 'I'. For example, '*I really feel...*', '*I strongly believe...*'; '*I am deeply convinced that...*'. To express your opinion use: 'argue', 'assert', 'claim'

B: Passive/active

The choice of whether to use the active or the passive voice should be determined by the degree to which you want to emphasise the subject or the object in a sentence. It is not the case that the passive is weak, nor is it the case that use of the passive is good academic style.

Example One:

Consider the following sentences:

The credit crunch [OBJECT] was partly caused by the sub-prime mortgage market.

Those banks [SUBJECT] that created the sub-prime mortgage market caused the credit crunch.

Both sentences are correct and perfectly acceptable in academic writing, but if you wish to emphasise the credit crunch itself then it makes sense to use the passive voice and place the object of the sentence at the start of the sentence. By contrast, if you choose to focus on the bankers (the subject of the sentence) it makes sense to use the active voice.

Example Two:

In some cases, where the subject of the sentence is unknown, the passive is clearly more appropriate,

e.g. *The power of the sun might be utilized for interstellar travel in the future.*

Example Three:

Equally, it makes little sense to use the active when focusing on things, events, processes etc.

Consider this sentence.

Lab technicians produce substance X by fusing together elements of Y and Z.

No doubt this is a true sentence, but we are not very interested in the lab technicians; we want to know about substance X.

So, the following sentence makes much more sense:

Substance X is produced by fusing together elements of Y and Z

Example Four:

Sometimes, the passive is not appropriate. Consider the following sentence:

It has been claimed that the internet has been detrimental to social cohesion.

This sentence might appear rather academic in style, but in fact it is an example of how NOT to use the passive in academic writing.

The problem with the sentence is that it doesn't tell us WHO made this claim, and since this is the most important part of the sentence, the active would have been more suitable, e.g.

Marks (2003) has claimed that the internet has been detrimental to social cohesion.

C: Formal/informal

A great deal is made of the need to write formally when writing in an academic style, but in most cases, it is more important to avoid informality than to employ highly formal terms.

Clarity is the most important feature of good academic writing, so if you are not sure how to use a word, it is better to choose a more straightforward term with which you are familiar.

Here, use of the dictionary or the thesaurus can lead you astray as synonyms cannot always be employed in the same way as each other.

Consider these sentences:

The Minister appropriated the decision.

The Minister took the decision.

The two sentences have quite different meanings, but in other contexts the words 'appropriate' and 'take' could be used synonymously.

Here, though, it is just confusing, so remember: *longer is not always better when it comes to the choice of words.*

Having said this, excessive use of informal language or style should be avoided.

In particular, idioms and proverbs should not be used and never be tempted to translate a saying that is popular in your own language into English as it will rarely, if ever, be suitable for use in an academic essay, e.g.

Every coin has two sides...

Or

In a nutshell...

You may think these are 'natural' and appealing phrases, but they are overused and have become clichés. If in doubt, keep it simple.



Finally, easy things to avoid are contractions (e.g. “I’ve” instead of “I have”), abbreviations of words (e.g. “govt.” instead of “government”), and any kind of slang (e.g. “kids” instead of “children”).

Acronyms (e.g. “UNESCO”) are acceptable, but the first time you introduce an acronym you should write it in full (e.g. “the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO)). After that you may use the acronym.